THE LONG-DISTANCE MOVE COMPANION

A practical guide to coordinating providers, deadlines, costs, storage, and the unexpected.

Your workbook is the live record. This guide helps you make decisions, coordinate handoffs, and respond when plans change.

A long-distance move often involves several companies, dates, payments, and addresses. Keep the plan in one place, confirm important details in writing, and check what else needs to change when one part of the plan shifts.

COMPANION GUIDE

Use the guide with your workbook

You do not need to do everything at once. Start with the next decision that could affect another booking, deadline, or payment. Record the result in the workbook so you do not have to reconstruct the plan from messages later.

A simple review rhythm

- **Weekly:** review upcoming due dates, provider confirmations, open issues, and payments due.
- **After an important call or email:** record the result, who owns the next action, and when you will follow up.
- **When plans change:** check every related booking, person, date, and cost before accepting a new arrangement.
- **During move week:** confirm the next day's arrival windows, access details, essential items, and contacts.

Where to record information

Workbook tab	Use it for
Dashboard	Move details and a quick view of tasks, budget, overdue items, and open contingencies.
Task Tracker	Actions, owners, due dates, status, and follow-up.
Providers	Contacts, quotes, deposits, balances, dates, and service terms.
Budget	Estimated and actual costs, payment status, and variance.
Contingencies	What changed, what it affects, the next action, who owns it, and whether it is resolved.

If a decision could affect another provider, a deadline, or a payment, record it and check the related arrangements.

1. Coordinate the handoffs

The challenge is often not one late company; it is what that delay changes elsewhere. A new pickup date might affect storage, lodging, delivery, or vehicle transport. Check the connected arrangements before confirming a new plan.

Map the main handoffs

Service or handoff	Confirm before move day
Packing / loading	Arrival window, what must be ready, access rules, and who directs the crew.
Container / storage	Delivery and collection dates, storage location, access hours, and release process.
Transportation	Pickup and delivery range, tracking method, and who provides updates.
Destination access	Parking, building hours, elevator or loading-dock reservations, and truck access.
Unloading	Arrival window, crew size or service scope, placement instructions, and payment timing.
Vehicle transport	Separate pickup/delivery windows, inspection process, and payment terms.

Build a timeline with breathing room

- Work backward from dates that are difficult to change: lease or closing deadlines, building reservations, travel, and provider availability.
- Ask whether a date is guaranteed, a window, or an estimate. Write down which it is.
- Avoid scheduling every service back-to-back without a realistic buffer.
- For each unresolved confirmation, create a follow-up task. Sending a message does not mean the issue is resolved.

2. Choose and confirm providers

Compare the service and terms, not just the headline price. A quote may exclude packing materials, stairs, long carries, shuttle service, storage, fuel, or other charges.

Questions to ask before booking

- What exactly is included and excluded?
- Is the price binding, non-binding, hourly, or based on another arrangement?
- What could change the price, and how will additional charges be approved?
- Which dates are confirmed and which remain tentative?
- When are the deposit and balance due, and what payment methods are accepted?
- Who is the day-of contact and who handles after-hours problems?
- What cancellation, rescheduling, damage, loss, and claims terms apply?
- Will a subcontractor perform any part of the service?

Before paying

- Verify the provider's identity and applicable license or registration for the service and route.
- Read the contract and service order; save copies of revisions and written confirmations.
- Confirm addresses, access constraints, dates, included services, and contact details in writing.

Request written booking confirmation listing the date, services, agreed price, and payment or cancellation terms. If it does not arrive, follow up through a verified customer-service channel before treating the booking as final.

3. Keep the budget and payments visible

The main transportation quote is only part of the total. Track estimated cost, actual cost, deposit, remaining balance, and due date separately so you can see both the total and the cash you need at each stage.

Costs to consider

- **Core services:** moving company, container, separate self-storage, destination unloading, and vehicle transport.
- **Preparation:** packing supplies, specialty packing, cleaning, repairs, donation, or disposal.
- **Travel:** fuel, lodging, meals, tolls, parking, pet travel, and alternate transportation.
- **Property logistics:** access fees, permits, elevator reservations, shuttle service, and temporary storage.
- **Transition:** utility and internet setup, overlapping rent or mortgage, deposits, and essential replacement purchases.
- **Contingency reserve:** money set aside for delay, rebooking, extra labor, or a property not being ready.

Use the workbook consistently

- Enter quotes in Providers; estimates for the main services flow into Budget.
- Enter final or updated costs in the Budget Actual column. Avoid typing the same estimate into multiple places.
- Track the deposit and balance due dates in the provider record.
- A positive variance means actual cost is above estimate. Record the reason rather than changing the estimate to hide the difference.

A contingency reserve is not money already spent. Count it as an actual cost only when an expense occurs.

4. Plan for storage and space limits

Storage may be needed because the destination is not ready, the move dates do not line up, or the new home has less room than expected. Treat storage as its own service with a start date, cost, access rules, and an eventual plan for getting belongings out.

Two common storage situations

Situation	Plan for
Home is not ready yet	Temporary storage duration, extension terms, access to essentials, delivery from storage to the home, and who will arrange the next move.
Belongings will not fit	What can be stored, how often you need access, whether the unit size is adequate, and the added cost of moving items in and out.

Questions to ask the storage provider

- Is storage included in the container or moving quote, or is it a separate company and contract?
- What are the monthly rate, deposit, insurance requirements, access fees, and payment due dates?
- Are there minimum terms, late fees, rate changes, or charges for extending the rental?
- What access hours apply, and can you retrieve items without arranging a full delivery?
- Who can accept a delivery into storage, and what paperwork or authorization is needed?
- How will items eventually move from storage to the destination, and what will that extra trip cost?

Add separate self-storage to Providers and Budget when it is a different service. Do not assume the container company’s storage option will meet every need.

5. Prepare both addresses and your essentials

Access problems can disrupt a carefully timed move. Check the origin and destination rather than assuming a large truck or container can reach either property.

Check at both ends

- Parking, loading zones, street width, gates, low branches, elevators, building hours, and required permits or insurance documents.
- Stairs, narrow doorways, long carries, oversized items, and whether a shuttle or alternate vehicle may be needed.
- Who will provide keys or entry, and whether the home will be ready on the delivery date.
- Building move-in rules, elevator reservations, loading-dock time, and delivery restrictions.

Keep these with you—not in the shipment

- Identification, contracts, inventory, important records, keys, wallet, phone, chargers, and payment cards.
- Medication, glasses, personal-care items, work essentials, and documents you cannot easily replace.
- A few days of clothes, toiletries, towels, bedding, basic cleaning supplies, and pet essentials if applicable.
- A copy of key confirmations and contact numbers accessible offline.

Keep essential items available in case the household shipment and vehicle arrive on different days.

6. Prepare for pickup, delivery, and vehicle transport

Treat vehicle transport as a separate booking with its own schedule, inspection, and payment record.

Before vehicle pickup

- Confirm exact pickup and delivery locations, windows, contact method, and whether service is door-to-door or terminal-based.
- Ask about fuel level, keys, alarms, toll devices, personal items, and vehicle requirements.
- Photograph the vehicle from several angles in good light, including existing marks, wheels, glass, and odometer.
- Review the condition report and keep a copy.

On household move day

- Keep the current schedule, inventory, contracts, and contact details available.
- Photograph valuable items and existing damage before loading; retain inventory and receipts.
- Record arrivals, delays, extra charges, and decisions while details are fresh.
- At delivery, inspect items and vehicle condition promptly. Document problems and follow the provider's claims process and deadlines.

Do not assume vehicle delivery and household delivery will happen on the same day. Plan for a gap between them.

7. When plans change: what else is affected?

When a delay or surprise charge occurs, use the same steps each time. The goal is to understand what is confirmed, see which arrangements are affected, and make a documented decision.

Step	What to do
1. Capture	Record what changed, when you learned it, and who provided the information.
2. Check related plans	List other providers, bookings, dates, people, access windows, and costs that could be affected.
3. Get options	Ask for workable alternatives, added costs, and the deadline for deciding—in writing.
4. Decide	Choose an option that protects your most important constraints and confirm who can authorize it.
5. Confirm	Get the revised plan and amounts in writing; tell every affected provider.
6. Update	Update tasks, provider details, budget, and contingency status in the workbook.

Common situations

If this happens…	Start by…
Loading crew is late	Get a revised window and check whether transport or building reservations need to change.
Destination is not ready	Confirm the new date, storage or lodging options, extra handling costs, and who will arrange delivery later.
Container cannot be placed	Confirm access limits and compare permitted alternatives, costs, and timing before agreeing.
Quote changes on move day	Ask for the reason, contract basis, itemized amount, and alternatives; document any approval.
Item is damaged or missing	Photograph the issue, note it on paperwork where possible, preserve records, and follow claim instructions and deadlines.

A contingency is not resolved just because someone replied. Close it when the issue is resolved or a clear, accepted plan is in place.

8. Keep communication and records clear

Short, specific messages help a busy representative act. Include the service, date, request, and response deadline.

Confirmation message

Subject: Please confirm [service / booking number]

Hello [name],

I'm confirming the current plan for [date] at [address]. My understanding is [service / arrival window / amount due]. Please confirm whether this is correct and identify anything still tentative.

Please also confirm [access requirement / balance due / next milestone] and let me know by [date/time] if anything has changed.

Thank you,
[name]

Schedule-change message

Subject: Schedule change affecting [booking]

Hello [name],

I was advised that [what changed] on [date/time]. This may affect [other booking, access window, or payment]. Please send the revised options, any added cost, and the deadline for choosing an option in writing.

I will update the other affected arrangements once the new plan is confirmed.

Thank you,
[name]

Keep records together

- Use folders for contracts, payments, inventory/photos, property access, vehicle transport, and claims.
- Name files consistently, such as YYYY-MM-DD_Provider_DocumentType.
- Keep key confirmations accessible offline and back up the workbook and important records securely.
- Check names, addresses, dates, rates, and special instructions before signing. Do not sign blank or materially inaccurate documents.

9. Arrival and first-week closeout

The move is not finished when the truck leaves. Closeout helps catch missing items, billing differences, and unfinished arrangements.

At delivery

- Check the inventory and visible condition; photograph damage or exceptions promptly.
- Keep signed delivery paperwork, receipts, and exception notes.
- Confirm any remaining balance and obtain a payment receipt.

During the first week

- Compare final invoices with estimates, deposits, contract terms, and approved changes.
- Submit claims or complaints within the applicable deadlines and keep submission records.
- Check remaining utility, internet, address-change, vehicle, and property tasks.
- Resolve open contingency items or assign an owner, next action, and follow-up date.
- Update actual costs and save a final copy of the workbook.

Final coordination checklist

Check	Ready?
Pickup and delivery windows reconfirmed; day-of contacts saved.	■
Access rules, parking, elevators, keys, and property readiness confirmed.	■
Deposits paid; balances, due dates, and receipts known.	■
Separate storage plan confirmed if needed, including access and eventual delivery.	■
Essentials and important documents kept accessible.	■
Delay/access fallback identified; open issues have an owner and next action.	■
Every affected provider has the same updated schedule after any change.	■

You do not need a perfect move. You need a clear current plan, reliable records, and a way to respond when the plan changes.

This guide supports planning and organization; it does not replace provider contracts, professional advice, or official requirements. Verify current licensing, consumer protections, building requirements, and claims deadlines for your specific services and route.

COMPANION GUIDE · Designed for use with the Long-Distance Move Planner workbook